

NON-MF GROUPS

SAUERS

We show that not every countable group is MF, where MF means admitting finite-dimensional unitary models that are asymptotically multiplicative and asymptotically separate nonidentity elements in operator norm. More precisely, the simple property-(T) group $H = \text{EL}_{12}(L_{\mathbb{F}_2}(1, 2))$ has trivial image under every homomorphism to an MF group. This group is also nonsofic, while its hyperlinearity remains open. Consequently its reduced group C^* -algebra is a separable stably finite C^* -algebra that is not MF. The proof rests on a one-sided compression criterion for Kazhdan subgroups in norm matrix coronas. We also prove an MF permanence theorem for HNN extensions whose edge isomorphism is implemented by a unitary of a norm matrix corona, and use it to show that recognizing MF groups from finite presentations is Π_2^0 -complete.

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1. INTRODUCTION

Not every countable group is MF. Our counterexample is

$$H = \text{EL}_{12}(L_{\mathbb{F}_2}(1, 2)).$$

The group H is countable, nontrivial, simple, and has property (T), but every homomorphism from H to an MF group is trivial. In particular, H is not MF. Its reduced group C^* -algebra $C_r^*(H)$ is separable and stably finite, but is not MF.

More precisely, a countable group G is *MF* if there are positive integers d_n and maps $V_n: G \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(d_n)$, with $V_n(1) = 1$, such that

$$\|V_n(gh) - V_n(g)V_n(h)\| \rightarrow 0 \quad (g, h \in G),$$

and

$$\limsup_n \|V_n(g) - 1\| > 0 \quad (g \in G \setminus \{1\}).$$

This is the operator norm notion of MF group introduced by Carrión–Dadarlat–Eckhardt [CDE].

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Equivalently, G embeds in the unitary group of the norm matrix corona associated to the sequence $\mathbf{d} = (d_n)$,

$$\mathcal{Q}_{\mathbf{d}} = \prod_n M_{d_n}(\mathbb{C}) / \bigoplus_n M_{d_n}(\mathbb{C}).$$

Here

$$\bigoplus_n M_{d_n}(\mathbb{C}) = \{(x_n) \in \prod_n M_{d_n}(\mathbb{C}) : \|x_n\| \rightarrow 0\}$$

is the c_0 -direct sum.

A separable C^* -algebra is called MF if it embeds as a C^* -subalgebra of a norm matrix corona. For every countable group G , the reduced group algebra $C_r^*(G)$ is separable and has a faithful canonical trace, hence is stably finite. Suppose that $e: C_r^*(G) \rightarrow \mathcal{Q}_{\mathbf{d}}$ is an MF embedding and put $p = e(1)$. Then $g \mapsto e(\lambda_g) + (1 - p)$ is an injective homomorphism from G into $\mathcal{U}(\mathcal{Q}_{\mathbf{d}})$, so G is MF. Therefore a non-MF group automatically gives a separable stably finite reduced group C^* -algebra that is not MF.

For a countable group G , define its MF radical by

$$\text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(G) = \bigcap_{\mathbf{d}} \bigcap_{\pi: G \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(\mathcal{Q}_{\mathbf{d}})} \ker \pi.$$

We call a homomorphism $G \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(\mathcal{Q}_{\mathbf{d}})$ a *corona homomorphism*. Proposition 2.1 shows that G is MF precisely when $\text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(G)$ is trivial. If $\text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(G) = G$, every homomorphism from G to an MF group is trivial.

For a subgroup $L \leq G$, put

$$\text{Comp}_G(L) = \{u \in G : uLu^{-1} \leq L\}$$

and define its *compression-centralizer defect* by

$$(1) \quad \mathfrak{D}_G(L) = \langle\langle [ucu^{-1}, \ell] : u \in \text{Comp}_G(L), c \in C_G(L), \ell \in L \rangle\rangle_G.$$

Theorem A (one-sided compression criterion). *Let G be countable and let $L \leq G$ have property (T). If $K \trianglelefteq G$ has property (T) and $K \leq \mathfrak{D}_G(L)$, then*

$$K \leq \text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(G).$$

In particular, a nontrivial such K makes G non-MF. If G has property (T) and $\mathfrak{D}_G(L) = G$, then $\text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(G) = G$.

We sketch the argument. Corollary 2.6 gives $\mathfrak{D}_G(L) \leq R_{\infty \rightarrow 2}(G)$. That is, every operator norm asymptotic representation of G is asymptotically trivial on $\mathfrak{D}_G(L)$ in normalized Hilbert–Schmidt norm. If a corona homomorphism were nontrivial on K , the Kazhdan projection of K would cut out a G -invariant corner on which K has no nonzero fixed vectors (Lemma 2.7); by the Kazhdan inequality some $s_0 \in K$ would then stay bounded away from the identity in normalized Hilbert–Schmidt norm along a subsequence, contradicting $s_0 \in \mathfrak{D}_G(L)$.

Theorem 2.2 gives a separate finite-dimensional vanishing result: every finite-dimensional linear representation of G over any field kills $\mathfrak{D}_G(L)$.

Property (T) is not itself an obstruction to MF approximation: every residually finite group is MF, including many Kazhdan groups. In the argument above, property (T) controls the fixed vectors of an exact corona representation. The one-sided compression forces the corresponding Kazhdan projection to commute with the compressor, which makes the Hilbert–Schmidt commutant invariant.

If G has a faithful finite-dimensional linear representation, then Theorem 2.2 gives $\mathfrak{D}_G(L) = 1$. The same conclusion holds if G is residually finite, because every nonidentity element then survives in a finite permutation representation. If G is amenable, its property-(T) subgroup L is finite [BHV]. In that case $uLu^{-1} = L$ for every $u \in \text{Comp}_G(L)$, so ucu^{-1} centralizes L and again $\mathfrak{D}_G(L) = 1$.

We next apply Theorem A to the group H .

Let $L_{\mathbb{F}_2}(1, 2)$ denote the binary Leavitt algebra. It is the unital $\mathbb{F}_2$ -algebra generated by s_0, s_1, t_0, t_1 subject to

$$(2) \quad t_i s_j = \delta_{ij}, \quad s_0 t_0 + s_1 t_1 = 1.$$

For a unital ring R , write $e_{ij}(a) = 1 + aE_{ij}$ and let $\text{EL}_n(R)$ be the subgroup of $\text{GL}_n(R)$ generated by the elements $e_{ij}(a)$, $i \neq j$.

Theorem B (the binary Leavitt group). *Put $R = L_{\mathbb{F}_2}(1, 2)$ and $H = \text{EL}_{12}(R)$. Then H is countable, nontrivial, simple, has property (T), and*

$$\text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(H) = H.$$

Equivalently, every homomorphism from H to an MF group is trivial. In particular, H is non-MF. Its reduced group C^ -algebra $C_r^*(H)$ is separable and stably finite, but is not MF.*

For any complete ordered binary leaf set C of cardinality 12, the matrix-ring isomorphism of Khanh–Thanh [K–T, Proposition 2.4] identifies $\text{GL}_{12}(R)$ with $R^\times$. Their equality $\text{GL}_{12}(R) = \text{EL}_{12}(R)$ [K–T, Proposition 4.2] therefore identifies H with $R^\times$. OpenAI proved that $R^\times$ is nonsofic [OAI, Chapter 3]. Thus H is nonsofic. Its hyperlinearity remains open.

Inside H , an explicit element τ satisfies $\tau L \tau^{-1} \leq L$ for the subgroup $L \cong \text{EL}_3(R)$ in the upper left. The element $c = e_{34}(1)$ centralizes L , and for $\ell = e_{12}(1)$ the corresponding commutator is

$$d = e_{02}(s_1 t_1).$$

The relation $t_1(s_1 t_1)s_1 = 1$ and the Steinberg commutator relations show directly that d normally generates H . Since $d \in \mathfrak{D}_H(L)$ and $\mathfrak{D}_H(L)$ is normal, it follows that $\mathfrak{D}_H(L) = H$. Therefore Theorem A gives $\text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(H) = H$.

We also determine the arithmetical complexity of MF recognition for finite presentations, in the Kleene–Mostowski hierarchy whose levels Σ_n^0 and Π_n^0 count alternations of quantifiers over a decidable relation.

Theorem C (recognizing MF groups). *Fix an effective coding of finite presentations of groups by natural numbers. The set of codes of finite presentations*

of MF groups is Π_2^0 -complete, and the set of codes of finite presentations of non-MF groups is Σ_2^0 -complete. In particular, neither set is recursively enumerable, and no algorithm decides from a finite presentation whether the presented group is MF. More precisely, there is a computable map $e \mapsto \hat{R}_e$ into finite presentations such that the group presented by $\hat{R}_e$ is MF if and only if the e -th partial computable function has infinite domain.

Proposition 4.3 gives a Π_2^0 description of the MF presentations: a presentation is MF exactly when finite certificates exist at every scale (Section 4). For hardness we reduce the Π_2^0 -complete set of programs with infinite domain to MF recognition: from e we construct a finite presentation $\hat{R}_e$ (Section 6). If the domain is finite, then $H \leq \hat{R}_e$, so $\hat{R}_e$ is not MF. If the domain is infinite, then $\hat{R}_e$ satisfies the hypotheses of Theorem 5.2, an MF permanence theorem for HNN extensions whose edge isomorphism is implemented by a unitary of a norm matrix corona, and is MF (Sections 5 and 7). The MF property is closed in the space of marked groups (Lemma 4.2; equivalently, it is closed under direct limits, by Korchagin [Kor, Proposition 13]), so every finitely generated group that is not MF is a quotient of a finitely presented one; Theorem C gives the uniform family and the exact level.

Relation to prior work. Blackadar and Kirchberg introduced the notions of MF and NF algebras in a 1994 Oberwolfach abstract [BK94]. They wrote that the classes of NF, strong NF, and separable nuclear stably finite C^* -algebras might coincide. Their 1997 paper developed these notions and proved that a separable C^* -algebra is NF if and only if it is nuclear and MF [BK]. It also asked whether every separable nuclear stably finite C^* -algebra is quasidiagonal. This was a question about nuclear C^* -algebras, not about arbitrary groups.

The group property used here was introduced by Carrión–Dadarlat–Eckhardt [CDE]. If every separable stably finite C^* -algebra were MF, then every countable group would be MF because its reduced group C^* -algebra is separable and stably finite. Later papers on approximation of groups relate the resulting operator norm problem to Kirchberg’s question [LO, Th]. The negative solution of the Connes embedding problem [JNVWY] yields separable stably finite C^* -algebras that are not MF, as Goldbring and Hart observe [GH, Proposition 6.1 and Remark 6.2]. Theorem B gives such an example among reduced group C^* -algebras. Korchagin subsequently developed permanence and local approximation results for MF groups [Kor]. Shulman proves that $A *_C A$ is MF whenever A is a separable MF C^* -algebra and $C \subseteq A$ is a C^* -subalgebra [Sh, Theorem 10]. She also proves that the full group C^* -algebras of amalgamated free products of amenable groups and of certain semidirect products are MF [Sh]. Nonapproximability was known for the unnormalized Schatten p -norms with $1 < p < \infty$ [DGLT, LO]. Bachner–Dogon–Lubotzky later proved nonapproximability for $p = 1$ [BDL]. The operator norm case $p = \infty$ remained open. They also identify stability

from operator norm to normalized Hilbert–Schmidt norm as a possible route to a non-MF group [BDL, Proposition 1.5]; that is the route taken here.

Leavitt introduced the algebras $L_K(1, n)$ as examples of rings with nonunique module rank [Lev]. The compression used here comes from their defining relations. The binary Leavitt algebra is purely infinite simple [AA], hence an exchange ring [Ara], and its center is the base field [AC]. Preusser classified the subgroups of GL_n over an exchange ring that are normalized by EL_n [Pre]. His sandwich theorem, together with the simplicity of the binary Leavitt algebra and the equality $Z(R) = \mathbb{F}_2$, implies that $EL_{12}(R)$ is simple (Proposition 3.3). Ershov–Jaikin–Zapirain give property (T) for $EL_n(R)$ whenever $n \geq 3$ and R is a finitely generated unital associative ring [EJZ, Theorem 1.1]. OpenAI used the binary Leavitt unit group to construct the first known nonscic group [OAI, Chapter 3]. Khanh–Thanh’s matrix-ring isomorphisms and their equality $GL_n(R) = EL_n(R)$ identify that group with the group H studied here [K–T]. The present argument applies the Leavitt compression to operator norm approximation. Related rigidity results for metric approximations of Kazhdan groups appear in [KT, AT, Dad].

Decision problems for finitely presented groups go back to Dehn, and the theorem of Adian and Rabin [Ad, Ra] shows that no Markov property (one that some finitely presented group has and that no group containing some fixed finitely presented group has) can be recognized from a finite presentation. Once a finitely presented non-MF group exists, the MF property is Markov, and Adian–Rabin gives undecidability; Theorem C gives the exact level. A classical Π_2^0 -complete recognition problem for finitely presented groups is torsion-freeness, by Lempp [Lem]. For recursively presented groups, Bilanovic–Chubb–Roven proved that every Markov property is Π_2^0 -hard to recognize [BCR]; their construction is the first step of Section 6. The passage from recursive to finite presentations is where the operator algebra enters: a generic Higman embedding does not preserve the MF property, and the HNN extensions of Section 6 are chosen so that Theorem 5.2 applies to them.

2. ONE-SIDED COMPRESSION AND THE MF RADICAL

This section proves Theorem A. Let $uLu^{-1} \leq L$. In a finite-dimensional representation ρ , conjugation by $\rho(u)$ maps the commutant of $\rho(L)$ into itself; the map is injective, hence surjective, so the commutant is invariant (Theorem 2.2). In a norm matrix corona the same conclusion is obtained for the Kazhdan projection of a property-(T) subgroup: conjugation moves the projection below itself, and stable finiteness of the corona forces equality (Section 2.3). A normal property-(T) subgroup contained in the compression defect then lies in the MF radical (Theorem 2.8).

2.1. The MF radical. For $N \trianglelefteq G$ define its *MF kernel closure* by

$$\text{cl}_{\text{MF}}^G(N) = \bigcap \{ \ker f : N \leq \ker f, f : G \rightarrow M, M \text{ MF} \}.$$

The image of a corona homomorphism from G is countable and is itself MF; conversely, every MF target embeds in a norm matrix corona. Thus $\text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(G) = \text{cl}_{\text{MF}}^G(1)$, and G/N is MF precisely when $\text{cl}_{\text{MF}}^G(N) = N$. This is a closure operation on the normal subgroups of one fixed group; it is unrelated to topological closure of classes of marked groups.

Proposition 2.1 (basic properties of the MF radical). *For every countable group G , the subgroup $\text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(G)$ is fully invariant, the quotient $G/\text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(G)$ is MF, and*

$$G/N \text{ is MF} \iff \text{cl}_{\text{MF}}^G(N) = N \quad (N \trianglelefteq G).$$

In particular, G is MF if and only if its MF radical is trivial.

Proof. An intersection of kernels is normal. If α is an endomorphism of G , $x \in \text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(G)$, and π is a corona homomorphism from G , then $\pi \circ \alpha$ kills x . Hence $\pi(\alpha(x)) = 1$ for every π , which proves full invariance.

Put $R = \text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(G)$. If G/R is trivial, there is nothing to prove. If $x \in G/R$ is nontrivial and $g \in G$ maps to x , then $g \notin R$. Some homomorphism from G to an MF group therefore separates g from the identity. It kills R and descends to a homomorphism from G/R that separates x . Thus G/R is residually MF, and hence MF by Korchagin [Kor, Proposition 6].

For $N \trianglelefteq G$, homomorphisms from G/N to MF groups correspond to homomorphisms from G to MF groups that kill N . It follows directly that

$$\text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(G/N) = \text{cl}_{\text{MF}}^G(N)/N.$$

Since a countable group is MF exactly when its MF radical is trivial, this identity gives the asserted closure criterion. $\square$

2.2. Finite dimension.

Theorem 2.2 (finite-dimensional commutant rigidity). *Let G be a group, let $L \leq G$, and suppose $u \in G$ satisfies $uLu^{-1} \leq L$. If k is a field, V is a finite-dimensional k -vector space, and $\rho: G \rightarrow \text{GL}(V)$ is a homomorphism, then*

$$\rho(u)\rho(L)'\rho(u)^{-1} = \rho(L)',$$

where $\rho(L)'$ is the commutant of $\rho(L)$ in $\text{End}_k(V)$. Consequently, if $c \in C_G(L)$, then

$$\rho([ucu^{-1}, \ell]) = 1 \quad (\ell \in L).$$

Proof. Put $C = \rho(L)'$. If $x \in C$, $h \in L$, and $h' = uhu^{-1} \in L$, then

$$\begin{aligned} \rho(h)\rho(u)^{-1}x\rho(u) &= \rho(u)^{-1}\rho(h')x\rho(u) \\ &= \rho(u)^{-1}x\rho(h')\rho(u) \\ &= \rho(u)^{-1}x\rho(u)\rho(h). \end{aligned}$$

Thus $\rho(u)^{-1}C\rho(u) \subseteq C$. Conjugation by $\rho(u)^{-1}$ is injective, and C is finite-dimensional. Its restriction to C is therefore surjective, so the inclusion is equality. Conjugating by $\rho(u)$ gives $\rho(u)C\rho(u)^{-1} = C$.

If $c \in C_G(L)$, then $\rho(c) \in C$, hence $\rho(ucu^{-1}) \in C$. Therefore $\rho([ucu^{-1}, \ell]) = 1$ for every $\ell \in L$. $\square$

The finite-dimensionality hypothesis cannot be dropped: an injective linear self-map of an infinite-dimensional commutant need not be surjective.

2.3. Kazhdan transport in normalized Hilbert–Schmidt norm. For $a \in M_d(\mathbb{C})$ write

$$\|a\|_2 = \text{tr}_d(a^*a)^{1/2}, \quad \text{tr}_d = \frac{1}{d} \text{Tr}.$$

An *operator norm asymptotic representation* of a countable group G is a sequence of maps $V_n: G \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(d_n)$ such that $V_n(1) = 1$ and

$$\|V_n(gh) - V_n(g)V_n(h)\| \rightarrow 0 \quad (g, h \in G).$$

For such a sequence put

$$K_2(V) = \{g \in G : \|V_n(g) - 1\|_2 \rightarrow 0\}.$$

The operator norm defects also tend to zero in normalized Hilbert–Schmidt norm, so $K_2(V)$ is a normal subgroup of G . Define

$$(3) \quad R_{\infty \rightarrow 2}(G) = \bigcap_V K_2(V),$$

where V ranges over all operator norm asymptotic representations of G .

For $L \leq G$, let

$$\mathcal{C}_2(V, L) = \left\{ (x_n) \left| \begin{array}{l} \sup_n \|x_n\| < \infty, \\ \|[V_n(\ell), x_n]\|_2 \rightarrow 0 \quad (\ell \in L) \end{array} \right. \right\}$$

be the bounded Hilbert–Schmidt asymptotic commutant of $V(L)$. Coordinatwise conjugation by $V_n(g)$ defines a bijection, denoted $\text{Ad}(V(g))$, of the bounded matrix sequences.

Lemma 2.3. *For every sequence of positive integers (m_n) , the norm matrix corona*

$$\prod_n M_{m_n}(\mathbb{C}) / \bigoplus_n M_{m_n}(\mathbb{C})$$

is stably finite. Consequently, unitarily equivalent projections in a norm matrix corona are equal whenever one is dominated by the other.

Proof. Suppose that $v^*v = 1$ in the corona, and let (x_n) be a bounded lift of v . Then $x_n^*x_n \rightarrow 1$ in norm. For all sufficiently large n , the matrix x_n is invertible, and the unitary $x_n(x_n^*x_n)^{-1/2}$ differs from x_n by $o(1)$. Thus v is represented by unitaries and $vv^* = 1$. The same argument applies to every matrix amplification of the corona. If A is a stably finite unital C^* -algebra, equivalent projections $p \leq q$ satisfy $p = q$. Indeed, if $w^*w = q$ and $ww^* = p$, then $w \in qAq$ is an isometry in the corner. The corner is finite because $w + (1 - q)$ is an isometry in A . Consequently $ww^* = q$, and hence $p = q$. $\square$

Lemma 2.4 (one-sided order for the Kazhdan projection). *Let L have property (T), let B be a unital C^* -algebra, and let $\pi: L \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(B)$ be a homomorphism. Denote by $P \in B$ the image of the Kazhdan projection under the extension $C_{\max}^*(L) \rightarrow B$. If $U \in \mathcal{U}(B)$ satisfies*

$$U\pi(L)U^* \subseteq \pi(L),$$

then

$$U^*PU \leq P.$$

Proof. Represent B faithfully and nondegenerately on a Hilbert space $\mathcal{H}$. The represented projection P is the orthogonal projection onto $\text{Fix } \pi(L)$. If ξ is L -fixed and $\ell \in L$, then

$$\pi(\ell)U^*\xi = U^*(U\pi(\ell)U^*)\xi = U^*\xi,$$

because $U\pi(\ell)U^*$ belongs to $\pi(L)$. Hence $U^*\text{Fix } \pi(L) \subseteq \text{Fix } \pi(L)$, so the range projection U^*PU is dominated by P in $B(\mathcal{H})$. Faithfulness of the representation gives the same projection inequality in B . $\square$

Theorem 2.5 (one-sided Kazhdan transport). *Let $L \leq G$ have property (T), and let $u \in G$ satisfy $uLu^{-1} \leq L$. Let (V_n) be an operator norm asymptotic representation of G . Then*

$$\text{Ad}(V(u))(\mathcal{C}_2(V, L)) = \mathcal{C}_2(V, L).$$

Proof. Fix $x = (x_n) \in \mathcal{C}_2(V, L)$ and let ω be a free ultrafilter. Regard $M_{d_n}(\mathbb{C})$ as a Hilbert space with its normalized Hilbert–Schmidt inner product, and form the ultraproduct of Hilbert spaces $\mathcal{K}_\omega$. Conjugation by the $V_n(g)$ defines a unitary representation σ of G on $\mathcal{K}_\omega$. Indeed, for unitaries A, B one has

$$\|\text{Ad}(A) - \text{Ad}(B)\| \leq 2\|A - B\|,$$

so the conjugation actions are multiplicative modulo c_0 because the multiplicative defects of (V_n) tend to zero in operator norm. The class $\xi = [x_n]_\omega$ is fixed by $\sigma(L)$.

For $g \in G$, let $\tilde{\sigma}(g)$ be the class of the coordinate operators $\text{Ad}(V_n(g))$ in the norm matrix corona

$$\mathcal{B} = \prod_n B(M_{d_n}(\mathbb{C})) / \bigoplus_n B(M_{d_n}(\mathbb{C})).$$

After choosing matrix units on each $M_{d_n}(\mathbb{C})$, this is a norm matrix corona with coordinate sizes d_n^2 . By the preceding estimate, $g \mapsto \tilde{\sigma}(g)$ is a homomorphism $G \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(\mathcal{B})$. Its restriction to L therefore extends to a $*$ -homomorphism $C_{\max}^*(L) \rightarrow \mathcal{B}$. Let $P \in \mathcal{B}$ be the image of the Kazhdan projection [AW]. Under the natural representation of $\mathcal{B}$ on $\mathcal{K}_\omega$, its range is $\text{Fix } \sigma(L)$. The projection identity below is proved inside $\mathcal{B}$; the representation of $\mathcal{B}$ on $\mathcal{K}_\omega$ is used only afterwards. Since $uLu^{-1} \leq L$, the unitary $U = \tilde{\sigma}(u)$ satisfies the hypothesis of Lemma 2.4, and hence $U^*PU \leq P$ inside $\mathcal{B}$. The two projections are unitarily equivalent. Lemma 2.3 therefore gives $U^*PU = P$,

so U commutes with P . Hence both $U\xi$ and $U^*\xi$ are fixed by $\sigma(L)$. Since ω was arbitrary, the corresponding Hilbert–Schmidt commutators converge to zero along the full sequence. Thus $\text{Ad}(V(u))$ and its inverse both preserve $\mathcal{C}_2(V, L)$, which proves the equality. $\square$

Corollary 2.6. *Let $L \leq G$ have property (T), let $uLu^{-1} \leq L$, and let $c \in C_G(L)$. Then*

$$[ucu^{-1}, \ell] \in R_{\infty \rightarrow 2}(G) \quad (\ell \in L).$$

Proof. Let (V_n) be an operator norm asymptotic representation. If $c \in C_G(L)$, then $(V_n(c)) \in \mathcal{C}_2(V, L)$. By Theorem 2.5, the same is true of $(V_n(u)V_n(c)V_n(u)^*)$. Asymptotic multiplicativity identifies this sequence in operator norm with $(V_n(ucu^{-1}))$; explicitly,

$$\|V_n(u)V_n(c)V_n(u)^* - V_n(ucu^{-1})\| \longrightarrow 0.$$

Therefore

$$\|V_n([ucu^{-1}, \ell]) - 1\|_2 \longrightarrow 0 \quad (\ell \in L).$$

Intersecting over (V_n) proves the claim. $\square$

2.4. Normal Kazhdan subgroups and the MF radical. Let $K \trianglelefteq G$ have property (T), and let p be the image of its Kazhdan projection under a corona homomorphism of G . Normality of K implies that p commutes with the image of G . Hence $q = 1 - p$ also commutes with that image, and in every nondegenerate representation of the corner $q\mathcal{Q}_{\mathbf{d}}q$ the induced representation of K has no nonzero fixed vectors.

Lemma 2.7 (central corona corners). *Let $\rho: G \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(\mathcal{Q}_{\mathbf{d}})$ be a homomorphism from a countable group, and let $q \in \mathcal{Q}_{\mathbf{d}}$ be a nonzero projection commuting with $\rho(G)$. Then, after passing to an infinite coordinate subsequence, there are nonzero projections $q_n \in M_{d_n}(\mathbb{C})$, integers $r_n = \text{rank}(q_n)$, unitary identifications $J_n: \mathbb{C}^{r_n} \rightarrow q_n\mathbb{C}^{d_n}$, and an operator norm asymptotic representation*

$$W_n: G \longrightarrow \mathcal{U}(r_n)$$

with $W_n(1) = I_{r_n}$. In the corona over the retained coordinates, the class of $(J_n W_n(g) J_n^)$ is the coordinate restriction of $q\rho(g)$.*

Proof. Lift q to projections q_n , and lift each $\rho(g)$ to unitaries $U_n(g)$, choosing $U_n(1) = I_{d_n}$. The first lift is obtained by spectral rounding; the second is obtained by polar correction, since the two unitarity defects of any lift converge to zero in operator norm. The commutation relation in the corona gives

$$\|q_n U_n(g) - U_n(g) q_n\| \longrightarrow 0 \quad (g \in G).$$

Consequently $q_n U_n(g) q_n$, viewed on $q_n\mathbb{C}^{d_n}$, has both unitarity defects converging to zero. For each fixed g , let $\widetilde{W}_n(g)$ be its polar correction whenever

both defects are at most $1/2$, and set $\widetilde{W}_n(g) = q_n$ at the finitely many earlier stages. Then $\widetilde{W}_n(g)$ is unitary in the corner and satisfies

$$\left\| \widetilde{W}_n(g) - q_n U_n(g) q_n \right\| \rightarrow 0.$$

For $g = 1$, the compression is already the identity q_n of the corner, so take $\widetilde{W}_n(1) = q_n$. Since $q \neq 0$, infinitely many q_n are nonzero. Retain and relabel those coordinates. Put $r_n = \text{rank}(q_n)$, choose a unitary $J_n: \mathbb{C}^{r_n} \rightarrow q_n \mathbb{C}^{d_n}$, and define

$$W_n(g) = J_n^* \widetilde{W}_n(g) J_n \in \mathcal{U}(r_n).$$

Conjugation by J_n preserves operator norms and multiplicative defects. Thus (W_n) is an operator norm asymptotic representation with $W_n(1) = I_{r_n}$. The displayed estimate identifies the class of $(J_n W_n(g) J_n^*)$ with the coordinate restriction of $q\rho(g)$. $\square$

Theorem 2.8 (normal Kazhdan radical theorem). *Let G be countable and let $K \trianglelefteq G$ have property (T) with $K \leq R_{\infty \rightarrow 2}(G)$. Then*

$$K \leq \text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(G).$$

Proof. Suppose that a homomorphism $\Theta: G \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(\mathcal{Q}_{\mathbf{d}})$ is nontrivial on K . Replace G by $\Theta(G)$, replace K by $\Theta(K)$, and denote the resulting inclusion into the corona again by Θ . The new K is a nontrivial normal property-(T) subgroup, since property (T) passes to quotients. It is contained in $R_{\infty \rightarrow 2}(G)$: every operator norm asymptotic representation of the new group, precomposed with the quotient map from the original group, is an operator norm asymptotic representation of the original group.

Let $p_K \in C_{\max}^*(K)$ be the Kazhdan projection and let p be its image in $\mathcal{Q}_{\mathbf{d}}$. Under any faithful representation of the corona, p is the projection onto the K -fixed vectors. Normality of K gives

$$\Theta(g)p\Theta(g)^* = p \quad (g \in G).$$

Indeed, in a faithful representation of the corona the two projections have ranges $\Theta(g) \text{Fix } \Theta(K)$ and $\text{Fix } \Theta(K)$; these agree because $gKg^{-1} = K$. Put $q = 1 - p$. The projection q is nonzero: if $p = 1$, then every vector is fixed by K , so every element of K has trivial corona image. Lemma 2.7 gives positive integers r_n and an operator norm asymptotic representation $W_n: G \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(r_n)$. Let $\widehat{\Theta}: G \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(\mathcal{Q}_{\mathbf{r}})$ be its corona homomorphism. Under the coordinatewise corner identifications, $\widehat{\Theta}$ is the coordinate restriction of $g \mapsto q\Theta(g)$.

Choose a finite Kazhdan set $S \subseteq K$ and a Kazhdan constant $\kappa > 0$. Represent $\mathcal{Q}_{\mathbf{r}}$ faithfully. The Kazhdan projection of K under $\widehat{\Theta}$ is zero, so $\widehat{\Theta}|_K$ has no nonzero fixed vectors, and the Kazhdan inequality gives, for the positive element

$$b = \frac{1}{|S|} \sum_{s \in S} (\widehat{\Theta}(s) - 1)^* (\widehat{\Theta}(s) - 1)$$

the inequality

$$b \geq \frac{\kappa^2}{|S|} 1.$$

The coordinate elements

$$b_n = \frac{1}{|S|} \sum_{s \in S} (W_n(s) - I_{r_n})^* (W_n(s) - I_{r_n})$$

represent b . Taking the normalized trace on $M_{r_n}(\mathbb{C})$ yields

$$\frac{1}{|S|} \sum_{s \in S} \|W_n(s) - I_{r_n}\|_2^2 \geq \frac{\kappa^2}{|S|} - o(1).$$

The order inequality for b says that the negative part of $b_n - (\kappa^2/|S|)I_{r_n}$ converges to zero in operator norm. Taking normalized traces gives the displayed inequality. After passing to a subsequence, one fixed $s_0 \in S$ therefore stays a positive Hilbert–Schmidt distance from I_{r_n} . This contradicts $s_0 \in K \leq R_{\infty \rightarrow 2}(G)$, established above. Thus every corona homomorphism kills K , as required. $\square$

Proof of Theorem A. For every $u \in \text{Comp}_G(L)$, $c \in C_G(L)$, and $\ell \in L$, Corollary 2.6 gives

$$[ucu^{-1}, \ell] \in R_{\infty \rightarrow 2}(G).$$

Normality of $R_{\infty \rightarrow 2}(G)$ therefore gives

$$\mathfrak{D}_G(L) \leq R_{\infty \rightarrow 2}(G).$$

Since $K \leq \mathfrak{D}_G(L)$, Theorem 2.8 now gives $K \leq \text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(G)$. Taking a nontrivial K gives the non-MF conclusion. Taking $K = G = \mathfrak{D}_G(L)$ gives $\text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(G) = G$.

A finite-dimensional linear representation over any field kills every generator of $\mathfrak{D}_G(L)$ by Theorem 2.2; its kernel is normal, so it contains $\mathfrak{D}_G(L)$. $\square$

The proof that H is non-MF uses operator norm control and does not decide whether H is hyperlinear.

3. THE BINARY LEAVITT GROUP

This section proves Theorem B. The relation $s_0 t_0 + s_1 t_1 = 1$ of the binary Leavitt algebra gives an element $\tau \in H$ with $\tau L \tau^{-1} \leq L$ for a copy L of $\text{EL}_3(R)$, and a commutator $d \neq 1$ in $\mathfrak{D}_H(L)$; since H is simple, $\mathfrak{D}_H(L) = H$, and Theorem A applies.

3.1. The self-compression. Throughout this section $R = L_{\mathbb{F}_2}(1, 2)$ and

$$p = s_0 t_0, \quad q = s_1 t_1.$$

The relations (2) give

$$(4) \quad p + q = 1, \quad t_1 q s_1 = 1.$$

In particular $q \neq 0$.

We use indices $0, \dots, 11$ for 12×12 matrices. We identify $\mathrm{GL}_3(R)$ with the subgroup of $\mathrm{GL}_{12}(R)$ consisting of the matrices $\mathrm{diag}(A, I_9)$. Define a map $\Psi: M_3(R) \rightarrow M_3(R)$ by

$$(5) \quad \Psi(A) = qI_3 + s_0At_0.$$

Here s_0At_0 denotes the matrix $(s_0a_{ij}t_0)_{ij}$. The relations $q^2 = q$, $qs_0 = t_0q = 0$, and $t_0s_0 = 1$, all consequences of (2), show that Ψ is multiplicative. Moreover,

$$\Psi(I_3) = qI_3 + s_0I_3t_0 = qI_3 + pI_3 = (p+q)I_3 = I_3,$$

so Ψ preserves the identity. Finally, $t_0\Psi(A)s_0 = A$, so Ψ is injective. Hence Ψ restricts to an injective group homomorphism $\mathrm{GL}_3(R) \rightarrow \mathrm{GL}_3(R)$.

To realize Ψ by conjugation on the embedded copy of $\mathrm{GL}_3(R)$, define the following 6×6 block matrices:

$$X = \begin{pmatrix} s_0I_3 & s_1t_0I_3 \\ 0 & t_1I_3 \end{pmatrix}, \quad Y = \begin{pmatrix} t_0I_3 & 0 \\ s_0t_1I_3 & s_1I_3 \end{pmatrix}.$$

A block multiplication using (2) gives $XY = YX = I_6$, so $Y = X^{-1}$. Put

$$(6) \quad \tau = \mathrm{diag}(X, Y) \in \mathrm{GL}_{12}(R).$$

A direct block multiplication gives

$$(7) \quad \tau \mathrm{diag}(A, I_9) \tau^{-1} = \mathrm{diag}(\Psi(A), I_9).$$

Lemma 3.1. *The matrix τ defined in (6) belongs to $\mathrm{EL}_{12}(R)$.*

Proof. Put $I = I_6$. The Whitehead factorization gives

$$(8) \quad \mathrm{diag}(X, X^{-1}) = \begin{pmatrix} I & X \\ 0 & I \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} I & 0 \\ -X^{-1} & I \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} I & X \\ 0 & I \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} I & 0 \\ I & I \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} I & -I \\ 0 & I \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} I & 0 \\ I & I \end{pmatrix}.$$

If $B = (b_{rs})_{r,s=0}^5 \in M_6(R)$, then

$$\begin{pmatrix} I & B \\ 0 & I \end{pmatrix} = \prod_{r,s=0}^5 e_{r,6+s}(b_{rs}), \quad \begin{pmatrix} I & 0 \\ B & I \end{pmatrix} = \prod_{r,s=0}^5 e_{6+r,s}(b_{rs}).$$

In either product, distinct off-diagonal matrix units have product zero, so no cross-terms occur. Every factor on the right-hand side of (8) therefore belongs to $\mathrm{EL}_{12}(R)$. Since $Y = X^{-1}$, its left-hand side is τ , and the result follows. $\square$

Set $H = \mathrm{EL}_{12}(R)$, and let $L = \mathrm{EL}_3(R) \leq H$ denote the image of the embedding $A \mapsto \mathrm{diag}(A, I_9)$.

Proposition 3.2. *The groups H and L have property (T), and $\tau \in H$ satisfies*

$$(9) \quad \tau L \tau^{-1} \leq L.$$

Proof. The ring R is generated by s_0, s_1, t_0, t_1 as a unital ring. The theorem of Ershov and Jaikin-Zapirain therefore gives property (T) for $\text{EL}_{12}(R)$ and $\text{EL}_3(R)$ [EJZ, Theorem 1.1]. Lemma 3.1 gives $\tau \in H$.

For $i \neq j$ and $a \in R$, equations (7) and (5) give

$$\tau e_{ij}(a) \tau^{-1} = e_{ij}(s_0 a t_0) \in L,$$

where the elementary matrices are viewed in the embedded copy of L . These matrices generate L , so (9) follows. $\square$

3.2. Simplicity and the full MF radical.

Proposition 3.3. *The group $H = \text{EL}_{12}(R)$ is nontrivial and simple.*

Proof. The ring R is purely infinite simple [AA], and therefore is an exchange ring [Ara]. Let $N \trianglelefteq H$. Since $H = \text{EL}_{12}(R)$, the subgroup $N \leq \text{GL}_{12}(R)$ is normalized by $\text{EL}_{12}(R)$. Preusser's sandwich theorem [Pre, Theorem 3] provides an ideal $I \trianglelefteq R$ such that

$$\text{EL}_{12}(R, I) \leq N \leq C_{12}(R, I).$$

Simplicity of R gives $I = 0$ or $I = R$. If $I = R$, then $\text{EL}_{12}(R, I) = H$, so $N = H$.

Suppose that $I = 0$. Then $N \leq C_{12}(R, 0) = Z(\text{GL}_{12}(R))$. A matrix that commutes with every $e_{ij}(1)$ is a scalar matrix λI_{12} . Commutation with $e_{ij}(a)$ for arbitrary $a \in R$ then gives $\lambda a = a \lambda$, so $\lambda \in Z(R)^\times$. Since $Z(R) = \mathbb{F}_2$ [AC, Corollary 4.3], we have $\lambda = 1$ and $N = 1$. Finally, $e_{01}(1) \neq 1$, so H is nontrivial. $\square$

Proposition 3.4. *Let*

$$c = e_{34}(1), \quad \ell = e_{12}(1), \quad d = [\tau c \tau^{-1}, \ell]$$

in H . Then

$$c \in C_H(L), \quad d = e_{02}(q) \neq 1, \quad \langle\langle d \rangle\rangle_H = H.$$

Proof. For $i, j \in \{0, 1, 2\}$ with $i \neq j$ and $a \in R$, we have $j \neq 3$ and $i \neq 4$. Hence the Steinberg relations give

$$[e_{ij}(a), e_{34}(1)] = 1.$$

These matrices generate L , so $c = e_{34}(1)$ belongs to $C_H(L)$.

Direct multiplication of the matrices in (6) gives

$$(10) \quad \tau c \tau^{-1} = e_{01}(q) e_{34}(1).$$

The second factor commutes with $\ell = e_{12}(1)$. The identity $[e_{ij}(a), e_{jk}(b)] = e_{ik}(ab)$ therefore gives $d = e_{02}(q)$, which is nontrivial because $q \neq 0$.

Let $N = \langle\langle d \rangle\rangle_H$. Since $t_1 q s_1 = 1$, the Steinberg relations give

$$[d, e_{23}(s_1)] = e_{03}(q s_1) \in N, \quad [e_{10}(t_1), e_{03}(q s_1)] = e_{13}(1) \in N.$$

Conjugation by elementary Weyl matrices gives $e_{ij}(1) \in N$ for every $i \neq j$. For $a \in R$ and distinct i, j, k ,

$$[e_{ik}(a), e_{kj}(1)] = e_{ij}(a) \in N.$$

Thus N contains every elementary generator of H , so $N = H$. $\square$

Proof of Theorem B. The ring R is a finitely generated $\mathbb{F}_2$ -algebra, so H is countable, and H has property (T) by the Ershov–Jaikin–Zapirain theorem for elementary groups over finitely generated rings [EJZ, Theorem 1.1].

The containment (9), the centrality of c relative to L , and Proposition 3.4 show that $d \in \mathfrak{D}_H(L)$. The subgroup $\mathfrak{D}_H(L)$ is normal and Proposition 3.4 gives $\langle\langle d \rangle\rangle_H = H$, so $\mathfrak{D}_H(L) = H$. The group H has property (T), so Theorem A, applied with $K = H$, gives $\text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(H) = H$. Proposition 3.3 shows that H is nontrivial and simple.

If M is MF and $f: H \rightarrow M$ is a homomorphism, compose f with a faithful corona embedding of M . Since $\text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(H) = H$, this composition and hence f are trivial. If H were MF, its identity homomorphism would contradict this conclusion.

Finally, $C_r^*(H)$ is separable because H is countable. Its canonical trace is faithful, so it is stably finite. If an MF embedding $e: C_r^*(H) \rightarrow \mathcal{Q}_{\mathbf{d}}$ existed and $p = e(1)$, then $h \mapsto e(\lambda_h) + (1 - p)$ would embed H in $\mathcal{U}(\mathcal{Q}_{\mathbf{d}})$. This contradicts the fact that H is not MF. $\square$

4. LOCALITY AND FINITE CERTIFICATES

The MF property is defined through sequences of models on all of G , but it is determined by finite data with a fixed separation constant. The reformulation is due to Korchagin [Kor]; this section derives the upper bound of Theorem C from it.

The following lemma is due to Korchagin [Kor, Proposition 7].

Lemma 4.1 (locality with fixed separation). *A countable group G is MF if and only if for every finite set $F \subseteq G$ containing 1 and every $\varepsilon > 0$ there are $d \geq 1$ and a map $V: F \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(d)$ with $V(1) = 1$ such that*

$$\begin{aligned} \|V(gh) - V(g)V(h)\| &\leq \varepsilon \quad \text{whenever } g, h, gh \in F, \\ \|V(g) - 1\| &\geq 1 \quad \text{for } g \in F \setminus \{1\}. \end{aligned}$$

Proof. Suppose first that G is MF. Apply Korchagin’s formulation with tolerance $\varepsilon/2$ and restrict the resulting map to F . It separates every element of $F \setminus \{1\}$ from the identity by at least $\sqrt{2}$. Replace its value at 1 by the identity. Before this replacement the defect at $(1, 1)$ gives $\|V(1) - 1\| < \varepsilon/2$. Products involving 1 are now exact, products equal to 1 have defect less than ε , and all other defects are unchanged. This gives the stated model.

Conversely, choose the stated maps along an increasing exhaustion of G , with defects tending to zero, and extend each map by the identity outside its finite domain. The resulting sequence is an MF model. $\square$

Lemma 4.2 (marked closedness). *The class of MF groups is closed in the space of marked groups. In particular, every finitely generated group that is not MF is a quotient of a finitely presented group that is not MF.*

Proof. An (F, ε) -model in the sense of Lemma 4.1 depends only on the multiplication table of F , that is, on which products gh with $g, h \in F$ lie in F and which elements of F are equal. If $G = \langle X \mid N \rangle$ is finitely generated and not MF, Lemma 4.1 gives a finite $F \ni 1$ and $\varepsilon > 0$ with no (F, ε) -model. Represent the elements of F by words in X ; the finitely many equalities among the words and their pairwise products that hold in G are consequences of finitely many relators $N_0 \subseteq N$, and the inequalities hold in every marked group mapping onto G . Hence every marked group that agrees with G on the finitely many words involved carries a table isomorphic to that of F , and so is not MF; this is closedness. Applied to $\langle X \mid N_0 \rangle$, which maps onto G and has the same table, it gives the finitely presented quotient. $\square$

We use the Kleene–Mostowski arithmetical hierarchy in its standard form [So]: a set $A \subseteq \mathbb{N}$ is Σ_1^0 if $A = \{x : \exists y R(x, y)\}$ for a decidable relation R , it is Π_1^0 if its complement is Σ_1^0 , and Σ_2^0 and Π_2^0 are the classes $\{x : \exists y \forall z R(x, y, z)\}$ and $\{x : \forall y \exists z R(x, y, z)\}$ with R decidable. Fix an effective coding of finite presentations by natural numbers, under which a code determines computably its number of generators and its finite list of relator words, and write G_P for the group presented by the code P . Let MF_{fp} be the set of codes P such that G_P is MF, and NONMF_{fp} its complement. Korchagin’s Proposition 8 [Kor] is the finite-presentation form of Lemma 4.1; the certificates below add normal-closure witnesses for the trivial words, which is what makes the relation decidable.

Proposition 4.3 (finite certificates). *There is a decidable relation $C(P, n, c)$ on triples of natural numbers such that a code P lies in MF_{fp} if and only if for every n there is c with $C(P, n, c)$. Consequently $\text{MF}_{\text{fp}} \in \Pi_2^0$ and $\text{NONMF}_{\text{fp}} \in \Sigma_2^0$.*

Proof. Let $P = \langle x_1, \dots, x_k \mid r_1, \dots, r_m \rangle$. A *certificate at scale n* is a triple $c = (d, \ell, \pi)$ consisting of a dimension $d \geq 1$, a labelling ℓ of every reduced word of length at most n in $x_1^{\pm 1}, \dots, x_k^{\pm 1}$ by one of the symbols T and S , and, for every word w labelled T , an expression of w as a product of conjugates of the relators and their inverses that freely reduces to w . Such an expression is checkable, and its existence forces $w = 1$ in G_P . Let $\Phi(P, n, c)$ be the statement that there are $U_1, \dots, U_k \in \mathcal{U}(d)$ with $\|r_i(U) - 1\| \leq 2^{-n}$ for $i \leq m$ and $\|w(U) - 1\| \geq 1/4$ for every word w labelled S , where $w(U)$ is the evaluation of w at $U_1, \dots, U_k$ with $x_j^{-1} \mapsto U_j^*$. Writing $U_j = A_j + iB_j$ with real matrices, unitarity is a system of polynomial equations, and a bound $\|X\| \leq t$ or $\|X\| \geq t$ on a matrix whose entries are polynomials in the variables is a semialgebraic condition, since $\|X\| \leq t$ holds precisely when $t^2 - X^*X$ is positive semidefinite. Thus $\Phi(P, n, c)$ is a sentence of the first-order theory of the ordered field of real numbers, and its truth

is decidable by Tarski's theorem [Ta]. Let $C(P, n, c)$ hold when c is a well-formed certificate at scale n whose T-expressions check and $\Phi(P, n, c)$ holds. Then C is decidable.

Suppose that G_P is MF. Fix n , let $L = \max(n, |r_1|, \dots, |r_m|)$, let F be the set of images in G_P of all words of length at most L , together with their inverses, and let $\varepsilon = 2^{-n}/(4L)$. Lemma 4.1 gives $V: F \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(d)$ with $V(1) = 1$, defect at most ε on F , and $\|V(g) - 1\| \geq 1$ for $g \in F \setminus \{1\}$. Put $U_j = V(\bar{x}_j)$, where $\bar{w}$ denotes the image of a word w in G_P . For $g \in F$ we have $g^{-1} \in F$ and $\|V(g)V(g^{-1}) - 1\| \leq \varepsilon$, so $\|V(g^{-1}) - V(g)^*\| \leq \varepsilon$. For a word $w = y_1 \cdots y_\ell$ of length $\ell \leq L$, all of whose prefixes have images in F , induction on ℓ gives $\|w(U) - V(\bar{w})\| \leq 2\ell\varepsilon$. In particular $\|r_i(U) - 1\| \leq 2L\varepsilon \leq 2^{-n}$. Label a word w of length at most n by T if $\bar{w} = 1$, with a normal-closure expression as witness, and by S otherwise; for the latter, $\|w(U) - 1\| \geq \|V(\bar{w}) - 1\| - 2n\varepsilon \geq 1 - \frac{1}{2} \geq \frac{1}{4}$. So $C(P, n, c)$ holds for this certificate.

Conversely, suppose that for every n some certificate $c_n = (d_n, \ell_n, \pi_n)$ satisfies $C(P, n, c_n)$, and choose $U^{(n)} \in \mathcal{U}(d_n)^k$ witnessing $\Phi(P, n, c_n)$. For each $g \in G_P$ fix a reduced word w_g representing g , with w_1 the empty word, and put $V_n(g) = w_g(U^{(n)})$. Then $V_n(1) = 1$. For $g, h \in G_P$ the word $t = w_g w_h w_{gh}^{-1}$ is trivial in G_P , so it is freely equal to a product of A conjugates of relators and their inverses, for some A depending on g and h but not on n . Since evaluation is a homomorphism on the free group, since the operator norm is unitarily invariant, and since $\|xy - 1\| \leq \|x - 1\| + \|y - 1\|$ for unitaries x, y ,

$$\|V_n(g)V_n(h) - V_n(gh)\| = \|t(U^{(n)}) - 1\| \leq A 2^{-n} \rightarrow 0.$$

For $g \neq 1$ the word w_g is nontrivial in G_P , so for $n \geq |w_g|$ the certificate c_n cannot label it T, hence labels it S, and $\|V_n(g) - 1\| \geq 1/4$. Thus $\limsup_n \|V_n(g) - 1\| \geq 1/4 > 0$, and G_P is MF.

The displayed equivalence exhibits MF_{fp} as $\{P : \forall n \exists c C(P, n, c)\}$, a Π_2^0 set, and its complement as a Σ_2^0 set. $\square$

5. HNN EXTENSIONS WITH A CORONA CONJUGATOR

Sections 2 and 3 used a one-sided conjugation in a norm matrix corona to obstruct operator norm approximation. Theorem C also needs a positive statement: if the edge isomorphism of an HNN extension is implemented by a unitary of a norm matrix corona, then the HNN extension is MF. The proof combines Ueda's corner realization of a universal HNN extension [Ue] with Shulman's compatible-embedding criterion for amalgamated free products [Sh, Theorem 20]. The regular character is used to prove that the HNN group embeds in the resulting MF algebra.

A countable group G admits a *tracial MF realization* (A, ρ, τ) if A is a separable unital MF C^* -algebra, $\rho: G \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(A)$ is a homomorphism, and τ is a tracial state on A with $\tau(\rho(g)) = 0$ for every $g \neq 1$. Since $\tau(1) = 1$, such

a group embeds in $\mathcal{U}(A)$, so it is MF. Padding blocks with zeros embeds every norm matrix corona $\mathcal{Q}_{\mathbf{d}}$ isometrically into $\prod_n M_n(\mathbb{C})/\bigoplus_n M_n(\mathbb{C})$, so the MF algebras of the introduction are exactly the separable C^* -algebras that embed in the latter corona, as in [BK, Sh].

Lemma 5.1 (residually finite groups). *Every countable residually finite group admits a tracial MF realization.*

Proof. Let G be countable and residually finite, and choose finite-index normal subgroups $N_1 \geq N_2 \geq \dots$ with $\bigcap_k N_k = \{1\}$; this is possible because G is countable. Let $d_k = [G : N_k]$ and let $\lambda_k : G \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(d_k)$ be the left regular representation of G/N_k . In the corona $\mathcal{Q}_{\mathbf{d}}$ put $\rho(g) = [(\lambda_k(g))_k]$; then ρ is a homomorphism into the unitary group. Fix a free ultrafilter ω on $\mathbb{N}$ and set $\tau([(x_k)_k]) = \lim_{\omega} \text{tr}_{d_k}(x_k)$, where tr_{d_k} is the normalized trace on $M_{d_k}(\mathbb{C})$; this is well defined because $|\text{tr}_{d_k}(x_k)| \leq \|x_k\|$, and it is a tracial state on $\mathcal{Q}_{\mathbf{d}}$. If $g \neq 1$, then $g \notin N_k$ for all large k , so $\text{tr}_{d_k}(\lambda_k(g)) = 0$ for all large k and $\tau(\rho(g)) = 0$. Let A be the C^* -algebra generated by $\rho(G)$ and the unit of $\mathcal{Q}_{\mathbf{d}}$; it is separable, unital, and MF, and $(A, \rho, \tau|_A)$ is a tracial MF realization of G . $\square$

Let G be a countable group, let $S \leq G$ be a subgroup, and let $\theta : S \rightarrow G$ be an injective homomorphism. The HNN extension

$$(11) \quad \Gamma_{\theta} = \langle G, t \mid tst^{-1} = \theta(s) \ (s \in S) \rangle$$

contains G by Britton's lemma [Bri].

Theorem 5.2 (HNN permanence with a corona conjugator). *In the situation of (11), suppose that G admits a tracial MF realization (A, ρ, τ) , and that for some norm matrix corona $\mathcal{Q}$ there are an injective $*$ -homomorphism $\iota : A \rightarrow \mathcal{Q}$ and a unitary $W \in \mathcal{Q}$ with*

$$W \iota \rho(s) W^* = \iota \rho(\theta(s)) \quad (s \in S).$$

Then Γ_{θ} admits a tracial MF realization. In particular, Γ_{θ} is MF.

Proof. Write $D = C^*(\iota \rho(G)) \subseteq \mathcal{Q}$, a separable C^* -algebra with unit $p = \iota(1)$, and let $B_0 = C^*(\iota \rho(S))$ and $B_1 = C^*(\iota \rho(\theta(S)))$, both containing p . Conjugation by W restricts to a $*$ -isomorphism $\Theta : B_0 \rightarrow B_1$ carrying $\iota \rho(s)$ to $\iota \rho(\theta(s))$. Let U be the quotient of the full unital free product $D * C(\mathbb{T})$ by the closed ideal generated by the elements $ubu^* - \Theta(b)$, $b \in B_0$, where u is the canonical unitary generator of $C(\mathbb{T})$. We write d and u for the images of $d \in D$ and u in U . By construction, U has the following universal property: whenever $\pi : D \rightarrow E$ is a unital $*$ -homomorphism into a unital C^* -algebra and $v \in \mathcal{U}(E)$ satisfies $v\pi(b)v^* = \pi(\Theta(b))$ for $b \in B_0$, there is a unique $*$ -homomorphism $U \rightarrow E$ extending π and sending u to v . We first embed U in an amalgamated free product, which Shulman's criterion shows to be MF, and then construct the required tracial state on the copy of Γ_{θ} inside U .

Step 1: U embeds in an amalgamated free product. Let $C = B_0 \oplus B_1$, $A_1 = M_2(D)$, and $A_2 = M_2(B_0)$, with inclusions

$$\iota_A(c_0, c_1) = \begin{pmatrix} c_0 & 0 \\ 0 & c_1 \end{pmatrix} \in A_1, \quad \iota_B(c_0, c_1) = \begin{pmatrix} c_0 & 0 \\ 0 & \Theta^{-1}(c_1) \end{pmatrix} \in A_2,$$

and let $P = A_1 *_C A_2$. Ueda's universal HNN corner construction [Ue, Proposition 2.4], with his stable unitary replaced by its adjoint to match the covariance convention in (11), identifies P with $M_2(U)$ and U with the corner ePe , where e is the common image of $\text{diag}(p, 0)$. Thus U embeds in P .

Step 2: P is MF. By Shulman's criterion [Sh, Theorem 20], the full amalgamated free product $A_1 *_C A_2$ of separable C^* -algebras is MF as soon as there are injective $*$ -homomorphisms φ_A and φ_B of A_1 and A_2 into one norm matrix corona with $\varphi_A \circ \iota_A = \varphi_B \circ \iota_B$. Identify $M_2(\mathcal{Q})$ with the norm matrix corona of the doubled dimension sequence, and let $\varphi_A: M_2(D) \rightarrow M_2(\mathcal{Q})$ be the entrywise inclusion and $\varphi_B: M_2(B_0) \rightarrow M_2(\mathcal{Q})$ the entrywise inclusion followed by conjugation by $\text{diag}(1, W)$. Both are injective, and on C ,

$$\varphi_B(\iota_B(c_0, c_1)) = \begin{pmatrix} c_0 & 0 \\ 0 & W\Theta^{-1}(c_1)W^* \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} c_0 & 0 \\ 0 & c_1 \end{pmatrix} = \varphi_A(\iota_A(c_0, c_1)),$$

because Θ is conjugation by W . Hence P is MF, and so is $U \cong ePe$.

Step 3: the tracial state. The functional $T = \tau \circ \iota^{-1}$ is a tracial state on $\iota(A) \supseteq D$ with $T(\iota\rho(g)) = 0$ for $g \neq 1$. In the GNS representation of D for T , the vectors $\xi_g = \iota\rho(g)\xi_T$, $g \in G$, are orthonormal, because $\langle \xi_g, \xi_h \rangle = T(\iota\rho(h^{-1}g))$. Their closed span is invariant under D , and on it $\iota\rho(g)$ acts as the left regular representation $\lambda_G(g)$ of G . Thus there is a $*$ -homomorphism $\pi: D \rightarrow C_r^*(G)$ with $\pi(\iota\rho(g)) = \lambda_G(g)$. Since $G \leq \Gamma_\theta$, the space $\ell^2(\Gamma_\theta)$ is a direct sum of copies of $\ell^2(G)$ indexed by the right cosets of G . Thus $\lambda_{\Gamma_\theta}|_G$ is a multiple of λ_G , and the assignment $\lambda_G(g) \mapsto \lambda_{\Gamma_\theta}(g)$ extends to a $*$ -homomorphism $C_r^*(G) \rightarrow C_r^*(\Gamma_\theta)$. Composing, we obtain $\sigma_0: D \rightarrow C_r^*(\Gamma_\theta)$ with $\sigma_0(\iota\rho(g)) = \lambda_{\Gamma_\theta}(g)$. The pair $(\sigma_0, \lambda_{\Gamma_\theta}(t))$ satisfies the covariance relation $\lambda_{\Gamma_\theta}(t)\sigma_0(b)\lambda_{\Gamma_\theta}(t)^* = \sigma_0(\Theta(b))$ for $b \in B_0$: on the generators $\iota\rho(s)$ both sides equal $\lambda_{\Gamma_\theta}(\theta(s))$, because $tst^{-1} = \theta(s)$ in Γ_θ , and two $*$ -homomorphisms that agree on generators agree on B_0 . The universal property of U gives $\sigma: U \rightarrow C_r^*(\Gamma_\theta)$ with $\sigma(\iota\rho(g)) = \lambda_{\Gamma_\theta}(g)$ and $\sigma(u) = \lambda_{\Gamma_\theta}(t)$.

Define $j: \Gamma_\theta \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(U)$ by $j(g) = \iota\rho(g)$ for $g \in G$ and $j(t) = u$. The defining relations of (11) hold in U , since $u\iota\rho(s)u^* = \Theta(\iota\rho(s)) = \iota\rho(\theta(s))$, so j is a homomorphism, and $\sigma \circ j = \lambda_{\Gamma_\theta}$ is injective, so j is injective. Let $A' = C^*(j(\Gamma_\theta)) \subseteq U$, a separable unital MF C^* -algebra, and let $\tau' = \tau_{\Gamma_\theta} \circ \sigma|_{A'}$, where τ_{Γ_θ} is the canonical trace $x \mapsto \langle x\delta_1, \delta_1 \rangle$ of $C_r^*(\Gamma_\theta)$. Then τ' is a tracial state on A' with $\tau'(j(r)) = \tau_{\Gamma_\theta}(\lambda_{\Gamma_\theta}(r)) = 0$ for $r \neq 1$. Hence (A', j, τ') is a tracial MF realization of Γ_θ . $\square$

Injectivity of j follows from $\sigma \circ j = \lambda_{\Gamma_\theta}$, not from the covariant pair $(\iota\rho, W)$, which need not be faithful; in the applications below it is not.

Corollary 5.3 (central HNN extensions). *If G admits a tracial MF realization and $S \leq G$ is any subgroup, then $\langle G, t \mid [t, s] = 1 \ (s \in S) \rangle$ admits a tracial MF realization.*

Proof. Apply Theorem 5.2 with θ the inclusion of S , with ι any injective $*$ -homomorphism of A into a norm matrix corona, and with $W = 1$. $\square$

6. THE COMPLEXITY OF RECOGNIZING MF GROUPS

Write W_e for the domain of the e -th partial computable function and

$$\text{INF} = \{e : W_e \text{ is infinite}\}, \quad \text{FIN} = \{e : W_e \text{ is finite}\}.$$

The set INF is Π_2^0 -complete and FIN is Σ_2^0 -complete [So, Chapter IV]. We now combine the obstruction of Theorem B with the permanence of Theorem 5.2: this section constructs a computable map $e \mapsto \hat{R}_e$ into finite presentations such that the presented group contains H when $e \in \text{FIN}$ and satisfies the hypotheses of Theorem 5.2 when $e \in \text{INF}$, so that it is MF if and only if $e \in \text{INF}$. The construction of Bilanovic–Chubb–Roven gives a recursively presented group C_e that is trivial when $e \in \text{INF}$ and contains H when $e \in \text{FIN}$. We embed C_e in a three-generated recursively presented group $Q_e = F/N_e$, use a Mihailova subgroup to detect N_e inside a finitely presented group, and apply two HNN extensions, in the manner of Higman’s rope trick [Hig], to obtain $\hat{R}_e$. This section proves that $\hat{R}_e$ is not MF when $e \in \text{FIN}$; Section 7 proves that it is MF when $e \in \text{INF}$.

A recursive presentation of H .

Lemma 6.1 (a recursive presentation of H). *The group $H = \text{EL}_{12}(R)$ is finitely generated and has decidable word problem. In particular, it has a recursive presentation on finitely many generators.*

Proof. Let Y be the set of elements $e_{ij}(a)$ with $i \neq j$ and $a \in \{1, s_0, s_1, t_0, t_1\}$. Since $e_{ij}(a + b) = e_{ij}(a)e_{ij}(b)$ and $[e_{ik}(a), e_{kj}(b)] = e_{ij}(ab)$ for distinct i, j, k , and since every element of R is a sum of monomials in the generators s_0, s_1, t_0, t_1 , induction on the length of a monomial shows that every $e_{ij}(a)$ lies in the subgroup generated by Y ; there is always an index $k \notin \{i, j\}$ because $12 \geq 3$. Thus $H = \langle Y \rangle$. The monomials in s_0, s_1, t_0, t_1 that contain no subword $t_i s_j$ and no subword $s_1 t_1$ form the standard reduced $\mathbb{F}_2$ -basis of R [Lev]. Products of reduced monomials are computed by the defining reductions, so equality in R is decidable. A word in $Y^{\pm 1}$ is therefore evaluated to an explicit 12×12 matrix over R , and it represents 1 in H exactly when that matrix is the identity. The set of words representing 1 is decidable, hence recursively enumerable, and $\langle Y \mid \text{that set} \rangle$ is a recursive presentation of H . $\square$

The group C_e .

Lemma 6.2 (the group C_e). *There is an algorithm that computes from e a recursive presentation, on a computable set of generators, of a group C_e such that C_e is trivial if $e \in \text{INF}$ and H embeds in C_e if $e \in \text{FIN}$.*

Proof. Apply the construction of Bilanovic–Chubb–Roven [BCR, Theorem 3.1] with positive group 1 and negative group H . It gives, uniformly in e , a recursive presentation of a group that is trivial on INF and contains a copy of H on FIN . $\square$

A three-generator embedding. Let $F = F(x, y, t)$ be the free group on x, y, t , and let $y_i = x^i y x^{-i}$ for $i \in \mathbb{Z}$. For a countable group C with a generating sequence $(c_i)_{i \geq 1}$, put $c_i = 1$ for $i \leq 0$ and

$$(12) \quad B(C) = \langle C * F(x, y), t \mid t y_i t^{-1} = c_i y_i \ (i \in \mathbb{Z}) \rangle.$$

Let $Q_+ = B(1) = \langle x, y, t \mid [t, y_i] = 1 \ (i \in \mathbb{Z}) \rangle$, let $q_+ : F \rightarrow Q_+$ be the quotient map, and let $N_+ = \ker q_+$.

Lemma 6.3 (the three-generator embedding).

- (1) $B(C)$ is an HNN extension of $C * F(x, y)$, so C embeds in $B(C)$; it is generated by x, y, t ; and a recursive presentation of $B(C)$ on x, y, t is computable from a recursive presentation of C . We write $B(C) = F/N_C$ and $q_C : F \rightarrow B(C)$ for the quotient map.
- (2) Killing C induces a surjection $B(C) \rightarrow Q_+$; hence $N_C \leq N_+$, with equality when C is trivial.
- (3) The assignment $x \mapsto (x_1, x_2)$, $y \mapsto (y, 1)$, $t \mapsto (1, t)$ defines an injective homomorphism $j : Q_+ \rightarrow P = F(x_1, y) \times F(x_2, t)$. In particular, Q_+ is residually finite.

Proof. (1) The elements y_i , $i \in \mathbb{Z}$, freely generate the normal closure of y in $F(x, y)$ [LS, Chapter I]. The retraction $C * F(x, y) \rightarrow F(x, y)$ killing C sends $c_i y_i$ to y_i , so a nontrivial reduced word in the $c_i y_i$ maps to a nontrivial word in the y_i ; hence the $c_i y_i$ freely generate a free subgroup, and $y_i \mapsto c_i y_i$ is an isomorphism between two free subgroups of the base. Thus (12) is an HNN extension, and the base, hence C , embeds by Britton’s lemma. The relation $c_i = t y_i t^{-1} y_i^{-1}$ shows that x, y, t generate $B(C)$, and substituting this expression for c_i into the relators of C and into (12) produces a recursive presentation on x, y, t , uniformly in the presentation of C .

(2) The relators of (12) map to the relators $[t, y_i]$ of Q_+ when every c_i is sent to 1, and the map is the identity on x, y, t .

(3) The relators $[t, y_i]$ are sent to $[(1, t), (x_1^i y x_1^{-i}, 1)] = 1$, so j is a homomorphism. Let N_0 be the normal closure of $\{y, t\}$ in Q_+ . Then $Q_+/N_0 = \langle x \rangle$ is infinite cyclic and the extension splits, so $Q_+ = N_0 \rtimes \langle x \rangle$. Rewriting the presentation of Q_+ over the transversal $\{x^n\}$ by the Reidemeister–Schreier method [LS, Chapter II] presents N_0 on the generators $y_n = x^n y x^{-n}$ and $t_m = x^m t x^{-m}$, $n, m \in \mathbb{Z}$, with relators the conjugates $x^m [t, y_n] x^{-m} = [t_m, y_{n+m}]$, that is,

all commutators $[t_m, y_n]$. Hence $N_0 = F(y_n : n \in \mathbb{Z}) \times F(t_m : m \in \mathbb{Z})$. Now $j(y_n) = (x_1^n y x_1^{-n}, 1)$ and $j(t_m) = (1, x_2^m t x_2^{-m})$, and the elements $x_1^n y x_1^{-n}$ freely generate the normal closure of y in $F(x_1, y)$, and likewise for t ; so j restricted to N_0 is an isomorphism onto the product of these two normal closures. Finally $j(x) = (x_1, x_2)$ has infinite order and $j(x)^k \notin j(N_0)$ for $k \neq 0$, because the exponent sum of x_1 in $j(x^k)$ is k for $n \in N_0$. Hence j is injective on $N_0 \rtimes \langle x \rangle$. Free groups are residually finite and residual finiteness passes to direct products and subgroups, so Q_+ is residually finite. $\square$

For $e \in \mathbb{N}$ let $Q_e = B(C_e) = F/N_e$ with C_e the group of Lemma 6.2, and write $q_e: F \rightarrow Q_e$. By Lemmas 6.2 and 6.3, a recursive presentation of Q_e on x, y, t is computable from e ; $N_e \leq N_+$; if $e \in \text{INF}$ then $Q_e = Q_+$, $N_e = N_+$ and $q_e = q_+$; and if $e \in \text{FIN}$ then $H \leq C_e \leq Q_e$.

Detecting N_e inside a finitely presented group.

Lemma 6.4 (Higman embedding and the Mihailova subgroup). *There is an algorithm that computes from e a finite presentation $\langle X_e \mid R_e \rangle$ of a group Λ_e , words $w_x, w_y, w_t \in F(X_e)$, and a finite generating set of a subgroup $M_e \leq F(X_e) \times F(X_e)$, such that $x \mapsto w_x$, $y \mapsto w_y$, $t \mapsto w_t$ induces an embedding $Q_e \rightarrow \Lambda_e$, and $M_e = \{(u, v) : u = v \text{ in } \Lambda_e\}$. Consequently, with*

$$K_e^0 = F \times F(X_e) \times F(X_e), \quad i_e(f) = (f, w_f, 1), \quad L_e^0 = F \times M_e,$$

where w_f is the image of f under $x \mapsto w_x$, $y \mapsto w_y$, $t \mapsto w_t$, the map $i_e: F \rightarrow K_e^0$ is injective and $i_e(f) \in L_e^0$ if and only if $f \in N_e$.

Proof. Higman's embedding theorem [Hig] embeds every finitely generated recursively presented group in a finitely presented group, and its proof is effective; an explicit algorithm producing the finite presentation and the embedding words from a recursive presentation is given by Mikaelian [Mik]. Apply it to the presentation of Q_e . Following Mihailova [Mih], let M_e be the subgroup of $F(X_e) \times F(X_e)$ generated by the pairs (z, z) , $z \in X_e$, and $(r, 1)$, $r \in R_e$. If $(u, v) \in M_e$ then $u = v$ in Λ_e , since this holds for the generators. Conversely, if $u = v$ in Λ_e , then uv^{-1} lies in the normal closure of R_e , so it is a product of conjugates $gr^{\pm 1}g^{-1}$ with $r \in R_e$, and $(gr^{\pm 1}g^{-1}, 1) = (g, g)(r^{\pm 1}, 1)(g, g)^{-1} \in M_e$; hence $(u, v) = (uv^{-1}, 1)(v, v) \in M_e$. The first coordinate makes i_e injective, and $(f, w_f, 1) \in F \times M_e$ if and only if $w_f = 1$ in Λ_e , if and only if $q_e(f) = 1$ because the embedding is injective, if and only if $f \in N_e$. $\square$

The two HNN extensions. Let $P = F(x_1, y) \times F(x_2, t)$ and $j: Q_+ \rightarrow P$ be as in Lemma 6.3, and put

$$K^g = F \times P, \quad L^g = \{(f, jq_+(f)) : f \in F\},$$

and define

$$K_e = K_e^0 \times K^g, \quad L_e = L_e^0 \times L^g, \quad i: F \rightarrow K_e, \quad i(f) = (i_e(f), (f, 1)).$$

Let

$$(13) \quad \Gamma_e = \langle K_e, v \mid [v, \ell] = 1 \ (\ell \in L_e) \rangle, \quad S_e = \langle i(F), v i(F) v^{-1} \rangle \leq \Gamma_e.$$

Lemma 6.5 (the first HNN extension).

- (1) K_e is a direct product of free groups of finite rank, hence finitely presented and residually finite; L_e is finitely generated; i is injective; and $i(F) \cap L_e = i(N_e)$.
- (2) Γ_e is finitely presented, and a finite presentation is computable from e . The natural map from the amalgamated free product $F *_{N_e} F$, in which $n \in N_e$ in the first copy is identified with n in the second copy, onto S_e , sending the first copy to $i(F)$ and the second to $v i(F) v^{-1}$, is an isomorphism.
- (3) There is a homomorphism $\tau_e: S_e \rightarrow Q_e$ with $\tau_e(i(f)) = q_e(f)$ and $\tau_e(v i(f) v^{-1}) = 1$ for $f \in F$.

Proof. (1) $K_e = F \times F(X_e) \times F(X_e) \times F \times P$ is a product of six free groups of finite rank, so it is finitely presented, and residually finite because free groups are. The subgroup L_e is generated by the basis of the first factor, the generators of M_e from Lemma 6.4, and the elements $(a, jq_+(a))$ for $a \in \{x, y, t\}$, so it is finitely generated. Injectivity of i is clear from the first coordinate. An element $i(f)$ lies in L_e if and only if $i_e(f) \in L_e^0$ and $(f, 1) \in L_e^g$; the first holds if and only if $f \in N_e$ by Lemma 6.4, and the second if and only if $jq_+(f) = 1$, that is, $f \in N_+$. Since $N_e \leq N_+$, the intersection is $i(N_e)$.

(2) The presentation (13) is finite once $[v, \ell] = 1$ is imposed only for the finitely many generators ℓ of L_e , and it is computable from e because K_e , L_e and i are. It is an HNN extension of K_e with both edge groups equal to L_e and the identity as edge isomorphism. The map from $F *_{N_e} F$ to S_e is well defined because $i(n) \in L_e$ commutes with v for $n \in N_e$. A reduced word of the amalgamated free product alternates between elements of the two copies of F lying outside N_e ; its image is a word $i(f_0) v i(f_1) v^{-1} i(f_2) \cdots$ in which every letter between consecutive occurrences of $v^{\pm 1}$ is some $i(f_k)$ with $f_k \notin N_e$, hence $i(f_k) \notin L_e$ by (1). Such a word contains no pinch $v^{\pm 1} \ell v^{\mp 1}$ with $\ell \in L_e$, so it is nontrivial in Γ_e by Britton's lemma.

(3) Define τ_e on $F *_{N_e} F$ by q_e on the first copy and by the trivial map on the second; both kill N_e , so the definition is consistent on the amalgamated subgroup, and (2) identifies $F *_{N_e} F$ with S_e . $\square$

The second HNN extension is

$$(14) \quad R_e = \langle \Gamma_e \times Q_e, u \mid u(s, 1)u^{-1} = (s, \tau_e(s)) \ (s \in S_e) \rangle,$$

whose edge maps $s \mapsto (s, 1)$ and $s \mapsto (s, \tau_e(s))$ are injective homomorphisms of S_e into $\Gamma_e \times Q_e$; so $\Gamma_e \times Q_e$ embeds in R_e by Britton's lemma. The presentation (14) lists the recursively enumerable relators of Q_e . Its finite

replacement is

(15)

$$\begin{aligned} \hat{R}_e = \langle \Gamma_e \times F, u \mid & u(i(a), 1)u^{-1} = (i(a), a), \\ & u(vi(a)v^{-1}, 1)u^{-1} = (vi(a)v^{-1}, 1) \quad (a \in \{x, y, t\}) \rangle, \end{aligned}$$

where $\Gamma_e \times F$ is equipped with the finite presentation of Lemma 6.5(2), the basis x, y, t of F , and the commutation relators between the two factors.

Lemma 6.6 (the finite presentation). *The groups $\hat{R}_e$ and R_e are isomorphic by the map that is the identity on Γ_e and on u and sends F onto Q_e by q_e . A code of the finite presentation (15) is computable from e .*

Proof. Both maps $f \mapsto u(i(f), 1)u^{-1}$ and $f \mapsto (i(f), f)$ are homomorphisms $F \rightarrow \hat{R}_e$, and they agree on the basis, so $u(i(f), 1)u^{-1} = (i(f), f)$ for all $f \in F$; likewise $u(vi(f)v^{-1}, 1)u^{-1} = (vi(f)v^{-1}, 1)$ for all f . If $n \in N_e$, then $i(n) \in L_e$ by Lemma 6.5(1), so $vi(n)v^{-1} = i(n)$ in Γ_e , and comparing the two relations gives $(i(n), n) = (i(n), 1)$, that is, $(1, n) = 1$ in $\hat{R}_e$. Hence the factor F of $\hat{R}_e$ factors through $Q_e = F/N_e$, and the relations of (15) become $u(s, 1)u^{-1} = (s, \tau_e(s))$ for s in the generating set $\{i(a), vi(a)v^{-1} : a \in \{x, y, t\}\}$ of S_e ; both sides define homomorphisms on S_e , so the relations hold for all $s \in S_e$. This defines a homomorphism $R_e \rightarrow \hat{R}_e$; conversely, the relations of (15) hold in R_e after $F \rightarrow Q_e$, because $\tau_e(i(a)) = q_e(a)$ and $\tau_e(vi(a)v^{-1}) = 1$. The two homomorphisms are mutually inverse on generators. Computability of the code follows from Lemmas 6.4 and 6.5. $\square$

Lemma 6.7 (the case $e \in \text{FIN}$). *If $e \in \text{FIN}$, then H embeds in $\hat{R}_e$, and $\hat{R}_e$ is not MF.*

Proof. For $e \in \text{FIN}$ we have $H \leq C_e \leq Q_e \leq \Gamma_e \times Q_e \leq R_e \cong \hat{R}_e$ by Lemmas 6.2, 6.3(1), 6.6 and Britton's lemma for (14). Restricting MF models to a subgroup shows that subgroups of MF groups are MF, and H is not MF by Theorem B. $\square$

7. THE CASE $e \in \text{INF}$

We now prove that $\hat{R}_e$ is MF for $e \in \text{INF}$ and deduce Theorem C. The tracial MF realization of R_e is constructed inside a norm reduced product of MF algebras, so we first record that separable subalgebras of such products are MF. For C^* -algebras B_n , $n \geq 1$, write $\prod_n B_n / \bigoplus_n B_n$ for the quotient of the bounded sequences by the sequences with $\|x_n\| \rightarrow 0$; its norm is $\limsup_n \|x_n\|$.

Lemma 7.1 (reduced products of MF algebras). *If every B_n is MF, then every separable C^* -subalgebra of $\prod_n B_n / \bigoplus_n B_n$ is MF. Moreover, $M_k(B)$ is MF whenever B is.*

Proof. The first assertion is the standard diagonal argument for MF algebras [BK]; see also its use in the proof of Korchagin [Kor, Proposition 6]. The second follows by applying M_k to an MF embedding, since M_k of a norm matrix corona is the corona of the dimension sequence multiplied by k . $\square$

Lemma 7.2 (tensor synchronization). *Let Γ be a countable group with a tracial MF realization (A_1, ρ_1, τ_1) , let Q be a countable group with homomorphisms $\beta_n: Q \rightarrow B_n$ to finite groups such that every $q \neq 1$ satisfies $\beta_n(q) \neq 1$ for all large n , let $S \leq \Gamma$, and let $\tau: S \rightarrow Q$ be a homomorphism. Suppose that for every n there is a homomorphism $\lambda_n: \Gamma \rightarrow G_n$ to a finite group with*

$$\ker(\lambda_n|_S) \leq \ker(\beta_n \circ \tau).$$

Then there are a separable unital MF C^ -algebra A , a homomorphism $V: \Gamma \times Q \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(A)$, a tracial state T on A with $T(V(g, q)) = 0$ for $(g, q) \neq (1, 1)$, and a unitary $W \in A$ with $WV(s, 1)W^* = V(s, \tau(s))$ for all $s \in S$. Consequently*

$$\langle \Gamma \times Q, u \mid u(s, 1)u^{-1} = (s, \tau(s)) \ (s \in S) \rangle$$

admits a tracial MF realization, and in particular is MF.

Proof. Let E_n be the image of $(\lambda_n, \beta_n): \Gamma \times Q \rightarrow G_n \times B_n$, a finite group of order k_n , and let L_n be its left regular representation on $\ell^2(E_n)$. Put $B'_n = A_1 \otimes M_{k_n}(\mathbb{C})$, which is MF by Lemma 7.1, let $E = \prod_n B'_n / \bigoplus_n B'_n$, and define

$$V(g, q) = [(\rho_1(g) \otimes L_n(\lambda_n(g), \beta_n(q)))_n], \quad T([(x_n)_n]) = \lim_{\omega} (\tau_1 \otimes \text{tr}_{k_n})(x_n),$$

for a free ultrafilter ω . Each coordinate of V is a homomorphism into a unitary group, so V is a homomorphism, and T is a tracial state on E because $|(\tau_1 \otimes \text{tr}_{k_n})(x_n)| \leq \|x_n\|$. If $g \neq 1$ then $\tau_1(\rho_1(g)) = 0$, so $T(V(g, q)) = 0$; if $g = 1$ and $q \neq 1$ then $\beta_n(q) \neq 1$ for all large n , the regular representation of a finite group has trace zero off the identity, and again $T(V(1, q)) = 0$.

The two homomorphisms $s \mapsto (\lambda_n(s), 1)$ and $s \mapsto (\lambda_n(s), \beta_n \tau(s))$ from S to E_n have the same kernel, namely $\ker(\lambda_n|_S)$, by the hypothesis. Their images are therefore isomorphic subgroups of E_n of the same order, isomorphic via $(\lambda_n(s), 1) \mapsto (\lambda_n(s), \beta_n \tau(s))$. The restriction of L_n to a subgroup of E_n is unitarily equivalent to the direct sum of as many copies of the left regular representation of that subgroup as it has right cosets, so there is a unitary $W_n \in M_{k_n}(\mathbb{C})$ with $W_n L_n(\lambda_n(s), 1) W_n^* = L_n(\lambda_n(s), \beta_n \tau(s))$ for all $s \in S$. Put $W = [(1 \otimes W_n)_n] \in E$; then $WV(s, 1)W^* = V(s, \tau(s))$ for $s \in S$. Let A be the C^* -algebra generated by $V(\Gamma \times Q)$ and W ; it is separable and unital, and MF by Lemma 7.1. The triple $(A, V, T|_A)$ is a tracial MF realization of $\Gamma \times Q$. For the last assertion, apply Theorem 5.2 to this realization. Let ι be an injective $*$ -homomorphism of A into a norm matrix corona and put $p = \iota(1)$. The element $\widetilde{W} = \iota(W) + (1 - p)$ is a unitary of the full corona and implements the required covariance on $\iota(A)$, so it is the required conjugator. $\square$

Lemma 7.3 (the case $e \in \text{INF}$). *If $e \in \text{INF}$, then $\widehat{R}_e$ admits a tracial MF realization; in particular, it is MF.*

Proof. Let $e \in \text{INF}$, so that $Q_e = Q_+$, $N_e = N_+$, $q_e = q_+$, and $\tau_e(i(f)) = q_+(f)$, $\tau_e(v i(f) v^{-1}) = 1$. By Lemma 6.6 it suffices to show that R_e admits a tracial MF realization, and by Lemma 7.2 applied to $\Gamma = \Gamma_e$, $Q = Q_+$, $S = S_e$ and $\tau = \tau_e$, it suffices to produce the data of that lemma.

The group K_e is residually finite by Lemma 6.5(1), hence admits a tracial MF realization by Lemma 5.1, and Γ_e is the central HNN extension of K_e over L_e , hence admits one by Corollary 5.3.

The group $P = F(x_1, y) \times F(x_2, t)$ is residually finite; choose finite-index normal subgroups $P_1 \geq P_2 \geq \dots$ of P with trivial intersection, let $r_n: P \rightarrow C_n = P/P_n$, and put $\beta_n = r_n \circ j: Q_+ \rightarrow C_n$ with j the embedding of Lemma 6.3(3). Since j is injective and the P_n decrease to the trivial group, every $h \neq 1$ has $\beta_n(h) \neq 1$ for all large n .

Let $G_n = (C_n \times C_n) \rtimes \langle \sigma \rangle$, where σ of order two exchanges the coordinates. Define λ_n on $K_e = K_e^0 \times (F \times P)$ by killing K_e^0 and sending (f, p) to $(r_n j q_+(f), r_n(p))$, and put $\lambda_n(v) = \sigma$. This respects the relations of (13): the factor L_e^0 of L_e lies in K_e^0 and is killed, and an element $(f, j q_+(f))$ of L^g is sent to $(r_n j q_+(f), r_n j q_+(f))$, which lies on the diagonal and commutes with σ . Hence $\lambda_n: \Gamma_e \rightarrow G_n$ is a homomorphism, and on the generators of S_e ,

$$\lambda_n(i(f)) = (r_n j q_+(f), 1), \quad \lambda_n(v i(f) v^{-1}) = (1, r_n j q_+(f)).$$

Let $\pi_0, \pi_1: S_e \rightarrow Q_+$ be the homomorphisms that are q_+ on one copy of F in $S_e \cong F *_{N_+} F$ and trivial on the other, as in Lemma 6.5(3); thus $\pi_0 = \tau_e$. The displayed formulas show that $\lambda_n|_{S_e} = (r_n j \pi_0, r_n j \pi_1)$, both sides being homomorphisms that agree on generators. Therefore

$$\ker(\lambda_n|_{S_e}) = \ker(r_n j \pi_0) \cap \ker(r_n j \pi_1) \leq \ker(\beta_n \circ \tau_e),$$

which is the hypothesis of Lemma 7.2. $\square$

Proof of Theorem C. By Lemma 6.6 the map $e \mapsto \widehat{R}_e$ is computable, by Lemma 7.3 the presented group is MF for $e \in \text{INF}$, and by Lemma 6.7 it is not MF for $e \in \text{FIN}$. Hence INF reduces to MF_{fp} and FIN reduces to NONMF_{fp} under computable many-one reductions. Since INF is Π_2^0 -complete and FIN is Σ_2^0 -complete, and since $\text{MF}_{\text{fp}} \in \Pi_2^0$ and $\text{NONMF}_{\text{fp}} \in \Sigma_2^0$ by Proposition 4.3, the two sets are complete at their levels. A Π_2^0 -complete set is not Σ_2^0 and a Σ_2^0 -complete set is not Π_2^0 , so neither set is recursively enumerable, and in particular neither is decidable. $\square$

The homomorphism V of Lemma 7.2 does not extend faithfully to R_e in the corona: the finite maps λ_n are trivial on the Mihailova factor, so W commutes with $V(\gamma, 1)$ for every $\gamma \in K_e^0$, although u does not commute with $(\gamma, 1)$ in R_e . Injectivity is obtained in Theorem 5.2 from the universal algebra. The following questions are open. It is not known whether the models of $\widehat{R}_e$ can be chosen to converge to $C_r^*(\widehat{R}_e)$ in operator norm, so that the reduced C^* -algebra itself is MF; the argument produces a tracial state

on an abstract MF algebra, not strong convergence. It is not known whether $\widehat{R}_e$ is hyperlinear for $e \in \text{INF}$, which would place the recognition problem for hyperlinearity at the same level. Finally, it is not known whether an analogous family of finitely presented groups exists for soficity; the construction of Lemma 7.2 has no counterpart for permutation models.

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USE OF AI AND FORMAL METHODS

Claude Fable 5 and GPT-5.6 Sol assisted with mathematical exploration, proof development, literature searches, Lean formalization, drafting, and editing. The author reviewed their output and is responsible for the manuscript. Lean 4 source is available at <https://github.com/SauersML/group-approximation>. The development verifies Theorems A and B, the finite certificates of Proposition 4.3, and the deduction of Theorem C from a computable family of finite presentations that is MF exactly on INF; the construction of that family in Section 6 and Theorem 5.2 are proved in the article. The repository also contains machine-checked results not used here, on MF radicals, the recognition of approximation properties, and related group constructions, with an indexed list of statements and declarations.

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